

Karur, India

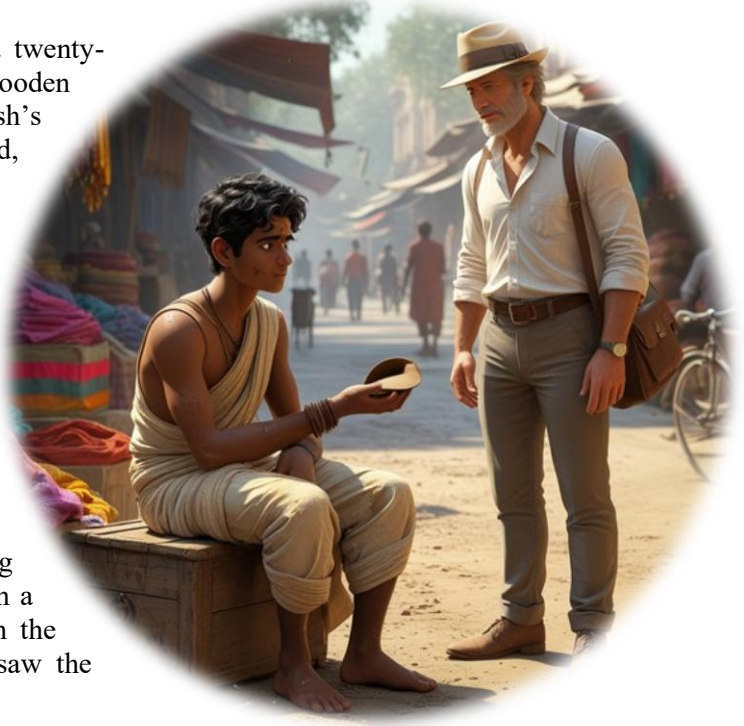
“What’s in the box you’re sitting on?”

The question came from Jean Louis, a French fabric merchant visiting Karur, a bustling textile city in southern India.

The young man he addressed was Prash, a twenty-year-old Indian boy, sitting on a weathered wooden old box on the edge of the busy street. Prash’s clothes were worn, his eyes tired. In one hand, he held out an old cap, begging for coins.

One year earlier, Prash had left his small hillside village where his family had a two-cow farm nestled on the green hills, to seek work in the city. But Karur city was unkind to the unprepared. The city’s indifference devoured his confidence, and when his hopes ran dry, he began to beg.

Jean Louis the French fabric merchant had just finished a successful morning sourcing fabric for his Parisian business in France. On a whim, he decided to wander about, through the offbeat parts of the city. That’s when he saw the young man on the box.



“Spare some alms?” Prash mumbled, barely meeting the man’s gaze.

Jean Louis looked at the boy, then at the box beneath him. The box was old, made of dark timber, weathered by time. “Why are you sitting on that box?” he asked. “What’s inside the box?”

Prash shrugged. “There is nothing in the box. It’s just an old box my grandfather gave me when I left home. He said I could rest on it during my walk to Karur. It belonged to his father before him—just family junk, really! I’ve often thought about throwing it away... but I couldn’t. It reminds me of home. Of my grandfather.”



“Have you ever looked inside?” Jean Louis asked.

“No,” said Prash. “Why bother? It’s just empty.”

“Still,” Jean Louis smiled, curious, “open it”.

Prash said ‘ I have not time, I must focus on begging to survive

Jean Louis responded, “I’ll give you 500 rupees if you open it.”

Startled but intrigued, Prash stood up, found a nearby vendor, and borrowed a spanner.

Together, he and Jean Louis began prizing the timber pieces off. Now they could see the inside of box.

At first, they saw nothing but layers of dried, brittle old grass. Prash gave Jean Louis a look.

“The 500 rupees please as you promised ?”

“Wait,” Jean Louis said, brushing the brittle old grass aside. His fingers struck something hard—cold, metallic. Beneath the brittle old grass lay gleaming bars of gold.

For a moment, the world fell silent.

Disbelief. Then astonishment. Then joy.

With Jean Louis’s guidance and the unexpected wealth from the old box, Prash returned to his village. He started fabric business, small at first with two assistants. But in time, with Jean Louis as his partner and mentor, the business flourished.



Today, Prash employs fifty people, local people who no longer have to leave their home village in search of work and hope. The old box now sits in his office, opened since that day, a quiet reminder that sometimes, we sit on treasure without ever knowing.

Peter Drucker, Management Expert wisely observed, "A weed is a weed until a new use is found for it," Drucker was an authority on innovation and opportunity recognition. He challenged that we check out ideas, even seemingly worthless things can have value if their potential is recognised and realized through new uses and/or applications.